

Skills Summary

Take-From and Comparison Stories Within Ten

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Every story below is one subtraction. Read the story, decide which picture it is, then write the equation with the unit.

- **Take from** — something leaves the group: $\text{start} - \text{went away} = \text{left}$.
- **Compare** — two groups, nothing leaves: $\text{bigger} - \text{smaller} = \text{difference}$.
- **Missing part** — the story hides a number: draw the whole group, then find what fills the gap.

1. Take-from stories

Start with the whole group. Cross out the things that go away. Count only the things with no cross on them. Say the unit with the answer.

Example: 7 birds sit on a fence. 3 birds fly away. How many birds are left?

Step 1. Birds leave the fence, so this is take-from and the count goes down.

Step 2. Draw 7 dots, cross out 3, and count the dots with no cross: $7 - 3$.

4 birds

Try it: 8 muffins are on a tray. 5 muffins are eaten. How many muffins are left?

check: 8 muffins

2. Comparison stories: how many more, how many fewer

Nothing goes away in a comparison. Line the two groups up, one under the other, and match them. The extras in the longer row are the answer. “How many more” and “how many fewer” ask for the *same* gap.

Example: There are 6 cats and 2 dogs. How many more cats than dogs?

Step 1. Both groups stay, so match them up instead of taking any away.

Step 2. Two cats pair with the 2 dogs. The unmatched cats are the answer: $6 - 2$.

4 more cats

Try it: A shelf has 7 blue books and 2 red books. How many fewer red books than blue books are there?

check: 5 fewer red books

3. Stories with a missing part

Sometimes the story tells you the start and the end, but not the change. Write the equation with a box for the number you do not know, then count back from the start to the end. Putting the part back is the check: it must return the start.

Example: A basket has 8 eggs. Some eggs are used. Now 5 eggs are left. How many eggs were used?

Step 1. The start and the ending amount are known and the change is missing, so write $8 - \square = 5$.

Step 2. Count back from 8 down to 5: 7, 6, 5 — that is 3 counts.

3 eggs

Try it: 9 ants are on a log. Some ants walk away. Now 2 ants are left. How many ants walked away?

check: 7 ants

Watch out. “More” does not mean add. In “Sam has 3 more shells than Tia”, the word more describes Sam, and finding Tia’s smaller number is a subtraction. Read the question again before writing the equation, and check that the answer is smaller than the group you started with.